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# TIPS & TIDBITS Newsletter

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## WORDS MATTER PREFERRED LANGUAGE FOR TALKING ABOUT ADDICTION

Addiction is a chronic but treatable medical condition. Often unintentionally, many people still talk about addiction in ways that are stigmatizing—meaning they use words that can portray someone with a substance use disorder (SUD) in a shameful or negative way and may prevent them from seeking treatment.<sup>9</sup> With simple changes in language harmful stigma and negativity around SUD can be reduced or avoided.

## “RECOVERY IS REAL” RESTORING EVERY ASPECT OF LIFE

This theme, promoted by SAMHSA, emphasizes the four key dimensions of recovery: health, home, community, and purpose. It highlights the idea that recovery is a comprehensive process encompassing various aspects of an individual's life.



## STIGMA & ADDICTION

### ***What is stigma?***

Stigma is discrimination against an identifiable group of people, a place, or a nation. Stigma about people with substance use disorders might include inaccurate or unfounded thoughts like they are dangerous, incapable of managing treatment, or at fault for their condition.



# “RECOVERY IS REAL” RESTORING EVERY ASPECT OF LIFE

## STIGMA & ADDICTION

Addiction is a chronic disease characterized by drug seeking and use that is compulsive, or difficult to control, despite harmful consequences.

The initial decision to take drugs is voluntary for most people, but repeated drug use can lead to brain changes that challenge an addicted person’s self-control and interfere with their ability to resist intense urges to take drugs.

These brain changes can be persistent, which is why drug addiction is considered a "relapsing" disease—people in recovery from drug use disorders are at increased risk for returning to drug use even after years of not taking the drug.

### **Where does stigma come from?**

Stigma around addiction may come from old and inaccurate ideas, or fear of things that are different or misunderstood.

Today, we know that addiction is a chronic, treatable medical condition. We also know that people can recover and continue to lead healthy lives.

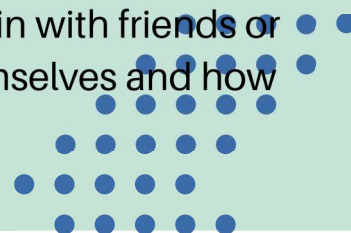
### **How does it affect people with SUD?**

Feeling stigmatized can make people with SUD less willing to seek treatment.

Negative stereotypes about people with SUD can make others feel pity, fear, and even anger.

### **How can we make a change?**

- When talking to or about people with SUD, make sure to use words that aren’t stigmatizing.
- Use person-first language, which focuses on the person—not their illness. It focuses on removing words that define a person by their condition or have negative meanings.<sup>4</sup> For example, “person with a substance use disorder” has a neutral tone and separates the person from his or her disorder.
- Let people choose how they are described. If you’re not sure what words to use, just ask! Check in with friends or loved ones about how they refer to themselves and how they would like others to refer to them.





## **What happens to the brain when a person takes drugs?**

Most drugs affect the brain's "reward circuit," causing euphoria as well as flooding it with the chemical messenger dopamine. A properly functioning reward system motivates a person to repeat behaviors needed to thrive, such as eating and spending time with loved ones. Surges of dopamine in the reward circuit cause the reinforcement of pleasurable but unhealthy behaviors like taking drugs, leading people to repeat the behavior again and again.

As a person continues to use drugs, the brain adapts by reducing the ability of cells in the reward circuit to respond to it. This reduces the high that the person feels compared to the high they felt when first taking the drug—an effect known as tolerance. They might take more of the drug to try and achieve the same high. These brain adaptations often lead to the person becoming less and less able to derive pleasure from other things they once enjoyed, like food, sex, or social activities.

Long-term use also causes changes in other brain chemical systems and circuits as well, affecting functions that include:

- learning
- judgment
- decision-making
- stress
- memory
- behavior

Despite being aware of these harmful outcomes, many people who use drugs continue to take them, which is the nature of addiction.





## Why do some people become addicted to drugs while others don't?

No one factor can predict if a person will become addicted to drugs. A combination of factors influences risk for addiction. The more risk factors a person has, the greater the chance that taking drugs can lead to addiction. For example:

- **Biology** - The genes that people are born with account for about half of a person's risk for addiction.
- **Environment** - A person's environment includes many different influences, from family and friends to economic status and general quality of life. Factors such as peer pressure, physical and sexual abuse, early exposure to drugs, stress, and parental guidance can greatly affect a person's likelihood of drug use and addiction.
- **Development** - Genetic and environmental factors interact with critical developmental stages in a person's life to affect addiction risk. Although taking drugs at any age can lead to addiction, the earlier that drug use begins, the more likely it will progress to addiction. This is particularly problematic for teens. Because areas in their brains that control decision-making, judgment, and self-control are still developing, teens may be especially prone to risky behaviors, including trying drugs.

### Can drug addiction be cured or prevented?

As with most other chronic diseases, such as diabetes, asthma, or heart disease, treatment for drug addiction generally isn't a cure. However, addiction is treatable and can be successfully managed. People who are recovering from an addiction will be at risk for relapse for years and possibly for their whole lives. Research shows that combining addiction treatment medicines with behavioral therapy ensures the best chance of success for most patients. Treatment approaches tailored to each patient's drug use patterns and any co-occurring medical, mental, and social problems can lead to continued recovery.

More good news is that drug use and addiction are preventable. Results from NIDA-funded research have shown that prevention programs involving families, schools, communities, and the media are effective for preventing or reducing drug use and addiction. Although personal events and cultural factors affect drug use trends, when young people view drug use as harmful, they tend to decrease their drug taking. Therefore, education and outreach are key in helping people understand the possible risks of drug use. Teachers, parents, and health care providers have crucial roles in educating young people and preventing drug use and addiction.

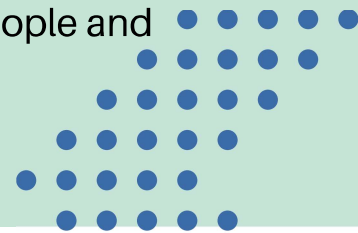


## **“RECOVERY IS REAL”**

### **RESTORING EVERY ASPECT OF LIFE**

### **Points to Remember**

- Drug addiction is a chronic disease characterized by drug seeking and use that is compulsive, or difficult to control, despite harmful consequences.
- Brain changes that occur over time with drug use challenge an addicted person’s self-control and interfere with their ability to resist intense urges to take drugs. This is why drug addiction is also a relapsing disease.
- Relapse is the return to drug use after an attempt to stop. Relapse indicates the need for more or different treatment.
- Most drugs affect the brain's reward circuit by flooding it with the chemical messenger dopamine. Surges of dopamine in the reward circuit cause the reinforcement of pleasurable but unhealthy activities, leading people to repeat the behavior again and again.
- Over time, the brain adjusts to the excess dopamine, which reduces the high that the person feels compared to the high they felt when first taking the drug—an effect known as tolerance. They might take more of the drug, trying to achieve the same dopamine high.
- No single factor can predict whether a person will become addicted to drugs. A combination of genetic, environmental, and developmental factors influences risk for addiction. The more risk factors a person has, the greater the chance that taking drugs can lead to addiction.
- Drug addiction is treatable and can be successfully managed.
- More good news is that drug use and addiction are preventable. Teachers, parents, and health care providers have crucial roles in educating young people and preventing drug use and addiction.





Medications for opioid overdose, withdrawal, and addiction are safe, effective, and save lives.



The National Institute on Drug Abuse supports research to develop new medicines and delivery systems to treat opioid use disorder and other substance use disorders, as well as other complications of substance use (including withdrawal and overdose), to help people choose treatments that are right for them.

Medications approved by the U.S. Food and Drug Administration for opioid addiction, overdose, and withdrawal work in various ways.

**Opioid Receptor Agonist:** Medications attach to and activate opioid receptors in the brain to block withdrawal symptoms and cravings.

**Opioid Receptor Partial Agonist:** Medications attach to and partially activate opioid receptors in the brain to ease withdrawal symptoms and cravings.

**Opioid Receptor Antagonist:** Medications attach to and block activity of opioid receptors in the brain. Antagonist medications that treat substance use disorders do so by preventing euphoric effects (the high) of opioids and alcohol and by reducing cravings. Antagonist medications used to treat opioid overdoses do so by reversing dangerous drug effects like slowing or stopping breathing.

**Adrenergic Receptor Agonist:** A medication that attaches to and activates adrenergic receptors in the brain and helps alleviate withdrawal symptoms.

## Talking About Yourself or Others with Substance Use Disorder

| Use...                                                                                                                                                            | Instead of...                                                                                                            | Because...                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Person with a substance use disorder<sup>10</sup></li> </ul>                                                               | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Addict</li> <li>User</li> <li>Substance or drug abuser</li> <li>Junkie</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Using person-first language shows that SUD is an illness.</li> <li>Using these words shows that a person with a SUD “has” a problem/illness, rather than “is” the problem.</li> <li>The terms avoid elicit negative associations, punitive attitudes, and individual blame.</li> </ul> |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Person with alcohol use disorder</li> <li>Person who misuses alcohol/engages in unhealthy/hazardous alcohol use</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Alcoholic</li> <li>Drunk</li> </ul>                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Person in recovery or long-term recovery/person who previously used drugs</li> </ul>                                       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Former addict</li> <li>Reformed addict</li> </ul>                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Testing positive (on a drug screen)</li> </ul>                                                                             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Dirty</li> <li>Failing a drug test</li> </ul>                                     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Use medically accurate terminology the same way it would be used for other medical conditions.</li> <li>These terms may decrease a person’s sense of hope and self-efficacy for change.</li> </ul>                                                                                     |

## Talking about Recovery and Treatment

| Use...                                                                                                                                                                                                                | Instead of...                                                                                                                                   | Because...                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Medication treatment for OUD</li> <li>Medications for OUD</li> <li>Opioid agonist therapy</li> <li>Pharmacotherapy</li> <li>Medication for a substance use disorder</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Opioid substitution</li> <li>Replacement therapy</li> <li>Medication-assisted treatment (MAT)</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>It is a misconception that medications merely “substitute” one drug or “one addiction” for another. <sup>5</sup></li> <li>The term MAT implies that medication should have a supplemental or temporary role in treatment. Using “MOUD” aligns with the way other psychiatric medications are understood (e.g., antidepressants, antipsychotics), as critical tools that are central to a patient’s treatment plan.</li> </ul> |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Being in remission or recovery</li> <li>Abstinent from drugs</li> <li>Not drinking or taking drugs</li> <li>Testing negative (on a drug screen)</li> </ul>                     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Clean</li> </ul>                                                                                         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Use of medical terminology (the same way you would for other illnesses) can help reduce stigma.<sup>8</sup></li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

## Talking about Babies Born to Parents Who Use Drugs

| Use...                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Instead of...                                                     | Because...                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>■ Baby born to a parent who used drugs while pregnant</li> <li>■ Baby with signs of withdrawal from prenatal drug exposure</li> <li>■ Newborn exposed to substances</li> <li>■ Baby with neonatal abstinence syndrome</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>■ Addicted baby</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>■ Babies cannot be born with addiction because addiction is a behavioral disorder.</li> <li>■ Using person-first language can reduce stigma.</li> <li>■ Use of medical terminology (the same way you would for other illnesses) can help reduce stigma.<sup>8</sup></li> </ul> |

